



EUROPEAN YOUTH PARLIAMENT
ITALIA ITALY



VERONA 2026

Crafting Unity: Weaving Local
Traditions into Europe's Future



ACADEMIC PREPARATION KIT



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Committee on Agriculture and Rural Development (AGRI)

Land for the Next Generation: *With nearly 1 in 3 EU farmers over 65 and only 11% under 40, combined with rising land prices, urban sprawl, and increasing concentration of farmland in large agribusiness holdings, access to land has become the biggest barrier for young farmers entering the sector. How can the EU ensure young farmers have access to land to grow crops and promote family farming and local food systems?*

by: Patrizia Ivan (IT)

Getting Started

Relevance of the Topic

Ensuring that young farmers have the space and resources to cultivate means safeguarding the **generational renewal** of an advanced production ecosystem, protecting the rural landscape from **urban sprawl**, and ensuring Europe's agricultural leadership continues to innovate and thrive rather than slide into [demographic stagnation](#). Discussing **access to land** for the next generation is not just a theoretical debate on European policy, but a **vital priority** for local territories across the continent.

The contrast between past structures and modern land highlights a systemic European challenge. In the post-war era, agricultural growth relied heavily on [multi-generational family cohesion](#), with farms passed down directly within highly localised networks. Today, Europe faces a severe intergenerational bottleneck due to [soaring land prices](#) and [shifting demographics](#). [Land values have soared](#) to among the highest levels in history, treating soil as a **financial asset**, pricing young, independent buyers entirely out of the market. Breaking down this barrier is essential for the future, allowing young people to invest in land and secure Europe's food sovereignty.

: You can have a look at [these](#) thematic reports by InterregEurope for further understanding.

Key Terms

- **[Generational renewal in agriculture](#):** it refers to the transition of land, assets, and operational leadership from outgoing farmers to younger ones or new entrants. It

describes the process of replacing an ageing workforce with new, younger entrants to ensure agricultural survival, innovation and sustainability.

- **Rural development**: the process of improving the economic well-being and quality of life for people living in sparsely populated or isolated rural areas.
- **Urban sprawl**: the rapid, often unplanned and uncontrolled outward expansion of a city into surrounding rural or undeveloped land.
- **Real estate speculation**: it consists of investing in properties or real estate assets and then reselling them later in the hope of realising a capital gain.
- **Demographic stagnation**: it is a state of population equilibrium where birth rates roughly equal death rates, resulting in zero or near-zero population growth.
- **Land mobility**: the ease and active transfer of land use or ownership between parties, primarily defined through leasing, selling or collaborative farming.

Stakeholders

- **Directorate-General for Agriculture and Rural Development (DG AGRI)**: the European Commission department that develops agricultural policy and drafts proposals for EU agricultural legislation. It manages the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP), which is a partnership between society and agriculture that ensures a stable supply of food, safeguards farmers' income, protects the environment and keeps rural areas vibrant.
- **Agriculture and Fisheries Council (AGRIFISH)**: consisting of the agricultural ministers from each of the 27 Member States. It represents national interests in Brussels, negotiating the flexibility that individual nations can have when implementing EU land-access programs. Member States have complete discretion over their own domestic land market and can independently decide how to regulate farmland ownership, concentration and pricing.
- **COPA-COGECA**: the strongest united agricultural lobby in the EU, a common umbrella for two different organisations. *COPA* represents European farmers as a whole, while *COGECA* represents European agricultural cooperatives. It ensures that land mobility policies do not harm the economic competitiveness of established cooperative structures.
- **CEJA (European Council of Young Farmers)**: it represents young farmers across Europe, and it actively lobbies the EU to reform land mobility and access to credit.

- **ECVC ([Via Campesina Europe](#))**: a grassroots confederation representing small-scale, peasant and family farmers. Unlike corporate lobbies, it campaigns for land ceilings¹ and argues that land should be treated as a human right and a public good, rather than a financial asset.
- **[Large Agribusinesses & Investment Funds](#)**: the corporate entities, such as International Woodland Company ([IWC](#)), [Aquila Capital](#) and [Generali Real Estate](#), driving farmland concentration. They treat land as a high-yield financial asset or use it for green energy infrastructure (solar fields), driving up land prices.

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

The rapid ageing of Europe's farming population underscores a stark structural reality, where roughly **one-third of [EU farmers are over the age of 65, and barely 11% are under 40](#)**. While institutional agreement exists on the need for rapid generational renewal, **access to land has emerged as a [barrier](#) for young entrepreneurs**, especially for new entrants coming from non-farming backgrounds who [cannot inherit family farmland](#). This crisis has sparked intense debates within the CAP and national governments.

Proponents of agricultural scaling argue that large-scale consolidation is necessary to achieve the economies of scale² that keep European farming globally competitive, providing the capital required to invest in advanced technology and precision farming. However, this model directly fuels **intense land concentration**, which destabilises rural communities: while large corporate farms prioritise high-yield efficiency, smaller, family-managed operations are often more flexible, vital for short supply chains and naturally aligned with the EU's biodiversity goals. This tension is further exacerbated by the rise of institutional land acquisition, creating a clash between food security and financial investment. As **soil is increasingly treated as a financial asset**, speculative capital drives up land values, pricing out independent young buyers who view land as a finite resource.

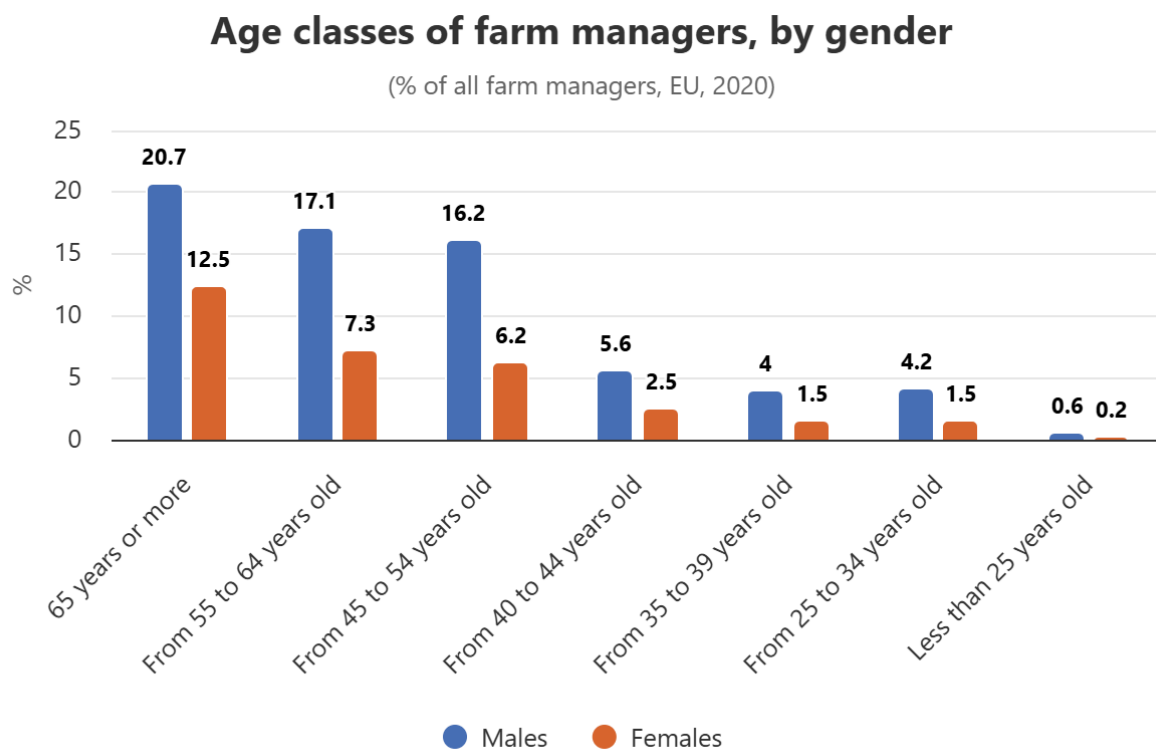
Finally, rising land values generate a dilemma between **agricultural preservation, urban sprawl** and **green energy projects**. Free-market advocates argue that regulating these land sales infringes on property rights and damages farmers' credit capacity³. Conversely,

¹ **[Land ceiling](#)**: a legal cap set by a government on the maximum amount of agricultural or urban land an individual or family can legally own.

² **[Economies of scale](#)**: economies of scale are cost advantages companies gain through efficient, increased production.

³ **[Credit capacity](#)**: it refers to how much credit you are able to handle.

interventionists warn that without strict regional protection, corporate speculation will destroy the primary purpose of farmland: ensuring food security and keeping rural communities alive.



[Figure 1](#): ‘Age classes of farm managers, by gender’, Directorate-General for Agriculture and Rural Development (2020).

🌱: Is the traditional family farm model still viable in modern Europe, or must young farmers adapt to corporate structures to survive?

🌱: Are short, local supply chains capable of feeding Europe, or are they a niche concept that cannot replace large-scale production?

🌱: How can the EU balance attracting private investment for green agricultural technologies with preventing speculative capital from driving up land values?

🌱: When farmland is sold, how should governments prioritise competing demands: food production, renewable energy projects or urban development?

Measures in Place

Lately, policy actions have been implemented regarding this matter; the CAP constitutes a case in point. It provides **financial stability** to those farmers who comply with strict environmental and social standards. Under the [EU's CAP 2023-2027 framework](#), the Complementary Income Support for Young Farmers ([CISYF](#)) requires Member States to dedicate at least 3% of their direct payments budget to young farmers, providing them with a reliable annual per-hectare top-up to stabilise operations during their volatile first five years. However, while this measure offers excellent operational liquidity, its real-world impact is structurally constrained.

European Union agricultural policy uses its funding and regulatory support to build a more sustainable and resilient farming sector. At the core of this framework is the [European Green Deal](#), which **coordinates agricultural practices** with **strict climate and biodiversity targets**, urging farmers to adopt organic farming, enhance animal welfare and implement ecoschemes. To prevent market distortions while enabling rapid national assistance, [Commission Regulation \(EU\) 2022/2472](#) establishes clear **state aid exemptions**. This regulation allows Member States to quickly roll out vital funding, such as investments in farm modernisation, support for young farmers, and compensation for extreme weather damage, without requiring prior Commission approval. Supporting these green ambitions on a broader scale, the European Investment Bank ([EIB](#)) works closely with the EU to bridge investment gaps in bioeconomy sectors. By [partnering with local financial institutions](#), the EIB co-finances high-impact projects that focus on renewable energy, carbon sequestration and environmental infrastructure, enabling the agricultural sector to make the **capital-intensive transition to cleaner practices**.

However, while the EU tightly regulates subsidies and environmental standards, other critical aspects of the agricultural land market remain entirely outside its jurisdiction. The EU does not regulate **farmland price caps**, leaving the determination of land costs up to individual domestic markets. Furthermore, the EU does not establish legal limits on **land concentration** or **foreign land ownership**, allowing national governments complete discretion over whether to restrict the accumulation of massive corporate estates or protect smaller family farms.

Focus on Italy

Member States are adopting their own measures to comply with the EU's CAP 2023-2027 framework; to cite a measure adopted in Italy and widely utilised in Verona, reference can be made to the [SRE01 measure](#). Funded by the European Agriculture Fund for Rural Development and managed through the Veneto Region's CAP Strategic Plan, this initiative

provides a vital single, **non-repayable start-up grant**, ranging from €40,000 to over €100,000 in disadvantaged areas, directly to new farmers under 40. Structurally, this is the most impactful tool currently active in Verona, **injecting immediate capital**. The [Youth Enterprise in Agriculture Act](#) was enacted specifically to address the ongoing “demographic winter” in Italian fields. This national framework introduces **aggressive tax reliefs, reduces registry fees for land transfers to young entrepreneurs, and a specialised national fund designed to prioritise youth-led family farms** in the redistribution of uncultivated or abandoned public land.

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

European institutions are considering a structural shift away from traditional area-based agricultural subsidies toward mechanisms that **favour younger entrants** and **mitigate financial speculation**. Proposed initiatives include establishing a [European Farmland Observatory](#) to monitor land values, capping payments for massive agribusinesses through degressive income support, and raising mandatory direct funding for young farmers to 8-10% of total interventions. While these reforms offer opportunities to enhance **land mobility**, provide **targeted capital**, and incentivise **agroecological transitions**⁴, they also face substantial hurdles. Implementing a unified strategy risks political friction regarding national land sovereignty, potential credit crunches for established family farms using land as collateral, and a smaller overall CAP funding pool due to broader budget consolidation.

⁴ [Agroecological transition](#): a long-term process of changing a standard farming model into a sustainable one by using natural ecological principles. It is based on the creation of mobilisation of knowledge from agroecology, the involvement of actors in the construction of this knowledge to tailor it to different territories, and territorialisation of agriculture, involving in particular a reconnection of agricultural production with food localism.



[Figure 2:](#) ‘Key policy objective of the CAP 2023-2027’, European Commission (2018)

Test your skills

- Want to challenge yourself and make sure it all clicked? Check out these key definitions to help you wrap your head around it! <https://jeopardylabs.com/play/committee-on-agriculture-and-rural-development>
- You can read “[Italy - CAP Strategic Plan](#)”, which is an overview of Italy’s formally approved strategy to implement the EU’s common agricultural policy (CAP) nationally, as well as information on the process and related documents.

Committee on Organised Crime, Corruption and Money Laundering (CRIM)

High Stakes: *Europe's drug market is rapidly expanding, valued at over EUR 30 billion annually and fuelling organised crime, with record drug seizures reflecting an increasing demand. As trafficking networks become more sophisticated and cross-border, how can the EU strengthen its response to drug trafficking while safeguarding fundamental rights?*

by: Pablo Silván (ES)

Getting Started

Relevance of the Topic

Over [30 billion euros](#)—that is how much Europe's illicit drug market is currently worth. This valuation exceeds the Gross Domestic Product¹ of some Member States such as [Malta](#), and is equivalent to the [average annual salary](#) of over 750,000 EU citizens. This cash flow has been a substantial revenue stream for criminal activity, which has increased [drug-related violence](#) and organised crime.

Despite legislative attempts within the EU to mitigate this situation, such as the [EU Drugs Strategy 2021–2025](#), the market has continued to grow. For **the past 7 years**, cocaine seizures have **increased annually**, reaching [419 tonnes](#) across EU Member States in 2023 alone. Hence, drug smugglers are [constantly operating](#) in increasingly sophisticated ways, exacerbating deeper social issues such as corruption and the [involvement of minors](#) in drug trafficking operations.

The consequences of drug-related Organised Crime Groups (OCGs) operating throughout the EU reach beyond the drug traffic itself, with approximately **50% of homicides within EU territory** being linked to drug-related violence. Consequently, authorities throughout the EU are [attempting to dismantle](#) both the market and its consequences.

: *How far can enforcement go? To what extent will effective measures such as surveillance, data sharing, and border control work without compromising the fundamental rights the EU claims to protect?*

¹ **Gross Domestic Product (GDP):** measures the total value of goods and services produced by that economy during a specific time period

Key Terms

- **Fundamental Rights:** The rights and freedoms guaranteed to individuals under the [EU Charter of Fundamental Rights](#), such as the rights to privacy, liberty, and a fair trial.
- **Organised Crime Groups (OCGs):** A structured group of three or more people, existing for a period of time, acting together to commit serious crimes for financial or material gain, as defined under [EU Framework Decision 2008/841/JHA](#).
- **Decriminalisation:** The removal of criminal penalties for an act, such as drug possession for personal use. The act may still be prohibited and subject to administrative sanctions like fines, but it no longer results in a criminal record. This differs from legalisation, which removes the prohibition entirely and permits regulated sale, as seen in [Germany's Cannabis Act](#) in 2024.
- **Harm Reduction:** A public-health approach that aims to reduce the negative health and social consequences of drug use, without necessarily requiring abstinence. This approach focuses on gradually helping at-risk groups and minimising the negative effects drugs have on their users.
- **Supply-side approaches:** Policies and interventions that focus on the source of the problem. For example, stopping cocaine shipments through Antwerp and Rotterdam.
- **Courier:** Often called a mule, someone who physically transports illegal drugs from one place to another. They act as carriers within drug-related OCGs, moving illicit substances across local, national, or international borders.
- **Drug Trafficking:** The production, manufacture, extraction, offering for sale, distribution, sale, delivery, brokerage, transportation, importation, or exportation of illicit drugs, [criminalised across the EU](#).

Stakeholders

- The **European Union Drugs Agency (EUDA)** is the EU's scientific centre of expertise on drugs. It monitors drug markets, issues early-warning alerts on new substances, and produces the evidence base, such as the annual European Drug Report. Its reports underpin EU drug policy. It aims to provide accurate, depoliticised data rather than creating or enforcing drug policy. The EUDA's mandate was [expanded in 2024](#) to cover drug-supply and drug-market issues in addition to its original public-health focus, opening up further scope for [collaboration with Europol](#), particularly its [European Serious and Organised Crime Centre](#), the unit that coordinates Europol's **operational response** to high-risk drug-trafficking networks.

- The [European Ports Alliance](#) is a public-private partnership between port authorities, customs, and shipping companies, launched in 2024. Ports have a direct commercial interest in remaining efficient trade hubs while reducing traffickers' exploitation of their facilities. They aim to reinforce security in all EU ports to cut off drug trafficking through the EU's external borders.
- The **European Union Agency for Law Enforcement Cooperation (Europol)** is the EU's law enforcement agency, which coordinates cross-border investigations, analyses intelligence regarding OCGs, and produces the [EU Serious and Organised Crime Threat Assessment](#). Europol has a direct interest in expanded intelligence sharing and closer cooperation among Member States.
- The [Council of Europe](#) is a separate international organisation from the EU, distinct from the European Council, and home to the [European Convention on Human Rights](#) (ECHR) and the European Court of Human Rights. The ECHR has a legal principle which requires measures restricting human rights, such as privacy, to be justified and proportionate. This provides an important benchmark against which new EU enforcement powers, including surveillance, data-sharing, and port controls, will be assessed.
- The **International Drug Policy Consortium (IDPC)** is a global civil society network of NGOs advocating for rights-based, health-oriented drug policy. It pushes back against purely punitive, supply-side approaches and lobbies for harm reduction to remain central to EU strategy.
- [Frontex](#), the European Border and Coast Guard Agency, supports Member States in securing the EU's external borders under [Regulation \(EU\) 2019/1896](#), which tasks it with contributing to the **prevention and detection of cross-border crime**, including drug trafficking.

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

Security vs. fundamental rights

As trafficking networks [grow more sophisticated](#) and use global shipping routes, the measures employed to stop them increasingly [rely on tools](#) such as communications interception, port scanning, and cross-border data sharing. Social groups [such as IDPC](#) complain about how the EU's current approach focuses disproportionately on supply-side measures, warning that these repressive and intrusive interventions can **erode privacy and**

other fundamental rights without proportionally reducing trafficking. The ECHR permits such interference only when necessary, and [no less restrictive alternatives exist](#).

Fragmentation of national regulations

Member States remain deeply divided on how to treat drug use itself. [Portugal](#) has **decriminalised possession of all drugs** since 2001, treating drug addiction and consumption as a health issue, while [Sweden](#) maintains a strict **zero-tolerance** model; Germany directly legalised recreational cannabis with the 2024 Cannabis Act. These inconsistencies between national regulations have become one of the EU's [greatest challenges](#) with drug-related policies, complicating many EU-wide responses and security cooperation between Member States.

Protecting vs. prosecuting exploited minors.

Criminal networks increasingly [recruit children](#), sometimes **as young as 12**, as couriers, lookouts, or shipment extractors. They are almost always recruited to perform these tasks as **minors face lighter legal consequences**. Enforcing harsher measures on drug-trafficking offences risks criminalising exploited children rather than the adults directing them. The European Parliament has called for these children [to be treated](#) primarily as victims; however, [implementation still varies widely by Member State](#).

Heterogeneous legislation

Drug trafficking goes beyond the substances consumed. The profits it generates must be laundered into **legitimate markets**, and moving shipments through the EU's borders depends heavily on corrupting the officials meant to stop them. Under the EU's new anti-money laundering package, money laundering and corruption are both listed as [predicate offences](#). In mid 2025, the [EU Anti-Money Laundering Authority](#), designed to **counter these predicate offences**, became operational. [Europol has identified corruption as the key enabler](#) that allows criminal networks to bribe port workers and even customs and law enforcement personnel to sneak drug shipments through major hubs such as Antwerp, Rotterdam, and Hamburg. [Europol also published reports](#) stating that the large majority of the EU's most threatening criminal networks infiltrate the **legal economy** to launder their profits, masked by **ordinary businesses**.

: *To what extent should fundamental rights be given up to have a more drug-free society?*

: How does the EU toughen enforcement against drug-trafficking networks without punishing their most vulnerable members?

: Should the EU push for a harmonised, harm reduction policy, or respect sovereignty and let states set their own approach to demand reduction within their borders, focusing EU action solely on cross-border supply?

Measures in Place

[Framework Decision 2004/757/JHA](#) remains the EU's baseline law, **setting minimum common definitions and penalties** for drug trafficking offences across Member States. It is currently under revision, with a reform expected by 2026, as many experts argue it is based on 20-year-old provisions that no longer reflect modern trafficking methods.

The EU Drugs Strategy 2021-2025 provided the political framework with which the EU acted until it was replaced in December 2025 by a new [EU Drugs Strategy and Action Plan against Drug Trafficking \(2026-2030\)](#), which places heavier emphasis on disrupting trafficking routes, protecting children from recruitment, and strengthening the EUDA's alert capacity. As the strategy and action plan have just been implemented, **it is still too early to assess their impact.**

The European Ports Alliance, launched in January 2024, brings together roughly 20 major ports, Europol, customs authorities, and shipping companies. The alliance seeks to reinforce security in all EU ports to cut off drug trafficking through the EU's external borders. They have been backed by over [€200 million](#) in EU funding for container-scanning equipment. This initiative has **improved information-sharing** but has not stopped traffickers from **shifting operations to smaller, less-monitored ports.**

Europol and Eurojust cooperation has driven some of the EU's biggest recent successes against drug trafficking by OCGs, particularly the exploitation of cracked encrypted platforms like [EncroChat and Sky ECC](#), which have led to hundreds of arrests and the **dismantling of major criminal networks** across multiple Member States.

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

Several elements of the EU's response are under negotiation. [The European Commission](#) is awaiting an **evaluation and a revision** of Framework Decision 2004/757/JHA. Additionally, it

is also working towards an updated EU Ports Strategy and updated rules regarding² precursor chemicals. [A Security and Innovation Campus](#) launching in 2026 to support new **detection technologies** is still in development.

Meanwhile, the EU still faces two controversial dilemmas that create significant underlying tension within the current political landscape. While some Member States push for a greater emphasis on **fundamental rights and a less invasive** approach towards reducing drug trafficking, others consider that it is **essential to crack down** on OCGs harder than ever. This links with the second challenge ahead of the EU: how to resolve the impeditive incoherence between harmonising drug policy EU-wide and respecting Member States' differing national approaches, from decriminalisation to zero tolerance. Both challenges are sure to shape debate for years to come.

² [Precursor Chemicals](#): Substances used to manufacture synthetic drugs, such as PMK used for MDMA and amphetamines. Their trade and diversion for illicit purposes are separately monitored and controlled under EU law.

Committee on Culture and Education (CULT)

Excuse my French: According to UNESCO's *Atlas of the World's Languages in Danger*, 128 languages within the EU are considered to be endangered. Considering this, how can the EU secure the preservation and promotion of regional and minority languages while also ensuring cultural integration within the Member States?

by: Noémi Szendrői (AT)

Getting Started

Elevator Pitch

Before diving into the Topic Overview, please watch this [video](#) to get a quick introduction to the topic!

Relevance of the Topic

Multilingualism is enshrined in the [EU Charter of Fundamental Rights](#) and is an important part of the cultural fabric of the EU. For instance, linguistic diversity fosters [cultural understanding, inclusion, and social cohesion](#), while [research](#) shows that multilingual individuals are better at **thinking creatively** and **innovatively**. Furthermore, language is a [key part](#) of **cultural identity**: history and knowledge are embedded within language; so when a language dies, part of this wisdom dies with it. Therefore, a European Union with many languages is a more [inclusive](#), [creative](#), and [culturally connected](#) Union.

Today, as [more than 120 languages](#) in the EU are regarded as **endangered**, this rich diversity is in **danger of being lost**. The development of the modern nation-state brought an official national language for education, bureaucracy, and most professional contexts; consequently, many minoritised languages have disappeared. The EU consists of 27 nation-states and has officially adopted [24 EU languages](#); however, **hundreds of other languages** are also spoken across the Union, and their institutional support and visibility are comparatively weak and, in many cases, declining. Many languages are at risk due to a [societal shift](#) to more widely used languages and a [general decline](#) of minoritised language speakers. Endangered languages can be **Regional and Minority Languages (RMLs)**, **indigenous languages**, or **non-territorial languages**.

 Read this [article](#) to find out more about the benefits of multilingualism and RMLs in the EU.

Key Terms

- **RMLs:** They are languages **traditionally used** within a state by a **minority of nationals** of that state. An RML is neither a dialect of the official language(s) **nor a language of migrants** that has historically not been spoken by a group of people in the area. Member States **determine specific RMLs** for their own country, and approximately 60 RMLs are recognised in the EU.
- **Non-territorial languages:** These are languages spoken by a group of people that **cannot be identified with a specific country or territory**, for example Romani or Yiddish.
- **Endangered languages:** UNESCO defines a language as vulnerable when it is spoken by children only in certain contexts, for example only at home; as definitely endangered when it is not learnt as children's mother tongue or spoken at home; as severely endangered when it is spoken by older generations and not spoken to the youngest generation; and as critically endangered when the youngest speakers of a language are at least grandparents, and it is spoken infrequently. Therefore, **an endangered language is a language that meets any of these criteria**.

Stakeholders

- The **Directorate-General for Education, Youth, Sport and Culture (DG EAC)** is a branch of the European Commission; it holds executive power and is responsible for culture, language, education, and youth, which specifically contributes to the preservation of endangered languages through programmes such as Erasmus+, which **fund initiatives** to promote minoritised languages' survival. However, the EU only has **supporting competence** over these areas, meaning that it can only support, coordinate, or complement any efforts by Member States to preserve endangered languages, for example, and cannot create any legally binding legislation that must be implemented into national law.
- Member States play a key role in the preservation of endangered languages, because under the European Charter for Regional or Minority Languages (ECRML) they must designate languages spoken by a minority in each individual country as RMLs and implement guidelines set forth by the charter for their protection. Furthermore, they are the **main actors** in the fight to preserve endangered languages, since Member States are **responsible for the creation of legislation and policy** regarding language, culture and education. Therefore, they decide which languages are granted **official or co-official status**, thus recognising and protecting RMLs and including

them as part of the public administration and education.

- **European Language Equality Network (ELEN)** is an NGO which defines its goals as the promotion and protection of lesser-used languages in the EU. Thus, it works towards equality for minoritised languages under the broader scope of human rights and multilingualism, as well as being the voice of minoritised language speakers. There are many RMLs represented under the NGO, such as [Kontseilua](#) in the Basque Country and [Rhieni dros Addysg Gymraeg](#) in Wales. The NGO works closely with the EU and has launched several initiatives for the preservation of endangered languages, for example the [Digital Language Diversity Project](#).
- **United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO):** The [UNESCO Atlas of the World's Languages in Danger](#) serves as an international database of endangered languages. Additionally, UNESCO has proclaimed the years of 2022 to 2032 as the [Indigenous Languages Decade](#), in which UNESCO plans a global effort to [mobilise stakeholders and resources](#) for the [preservation, revitalisation and promotion](#) of endangered languages.

💡: Look at this stakeholder map to further understand the connections between the stakeholders, and how they all contribute to the protection and promotion of endangered languages together:

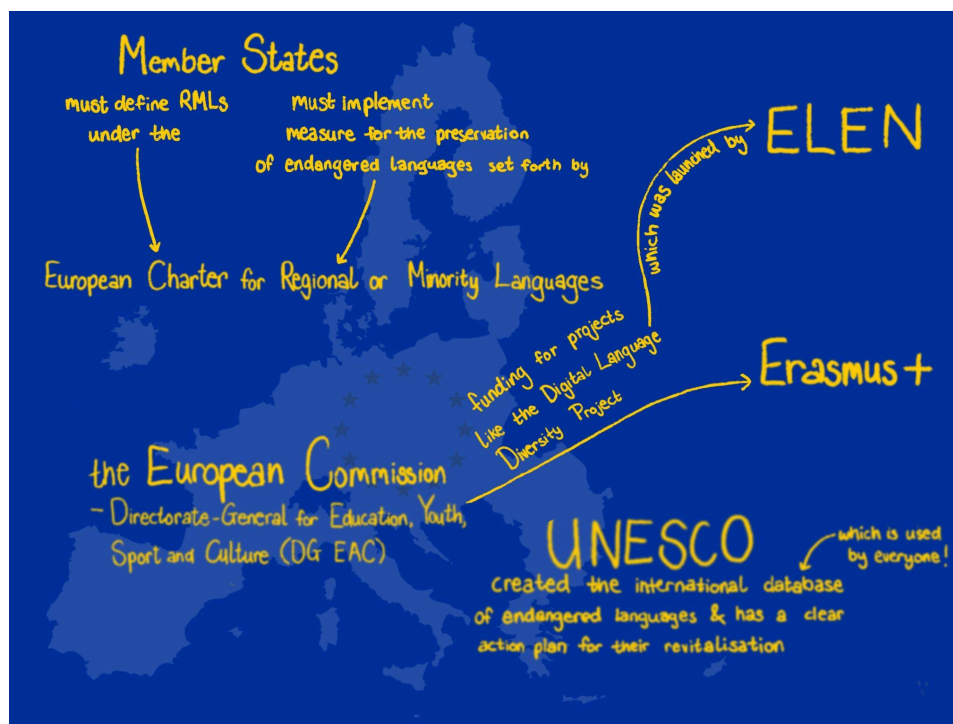


Figure 1: Map of stakeholders (self-made)

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

Dominant languages and social mobility

According to François Alfonsi, former co-chair of the Intergroup on Traditional Minorities, National Communities, and Languages, there is an **artificial hierarchy created between languages**. More widely spoken languages are **given priority over minoritised languages** because they are thought to be [more useful in later life](#). In this line, the [economic viability](#) of a language is a factor Member States may take into account when considering the scope of protection of a language as an RML. Furthermore, if a language is not considered economically valuable, a parent is [less likely](#) to pass it on to their child, because they believe speaking the dominant language of their country will create [access to more job opportunities](#) for their children. This directly correlates to the trend of [growing urbanisation](#), since **people in rural areas move to cities** for the [same reasons](#). Urbanisation is a [threat](#) to endangered languages, because when speakers of a minority language move to urban centres where the dominant language prevails, the native tongue is [in danger](#) of being lost.

Education and lack of linguistic infrastructure

Children widely [prefer](#) the language they hear at school over the language spoken at home, meaning that if they only hear their mother tongue at home, they start to [favour](#) the dominant national language used at school in everyday situations. This means that a language spoken by a minority will decline in use due to a child's lack of verbal confidence, making it [less likely](#) for them to pass on their mother tongue to their own children. However, **education in minoritised languages is not possible** when a language **does not have basic linguistic infrastructure** such as dictionaries, comprehensive grammar systems, and a corpus of texts, which many RMLs, such as [Karelian](#) or [Romani](#), [lack](#). Therefore, **even though education in the native language is vital** to the preservation of minority languages, it is often [not possible](#).

Digitalisation and globalisation

Due to [increasing digitalisation and globalisation](#), **English is becoming more and more prevalent** in EU citizens' lives. Minority languages [lose the stage](#) on the Internet, as well as in many professional contexts, to English and other national languages. With young people using the Internet as their [main means](#) of communication and information-gathering, **less widely used languages could become “digitally extinct”**.

💡: How can a child from a minority group have the same opportunities as their friends who speak the national language at home, without losing connection to their heritage?

💡: In what way could education in minoritised languages be made available and accessible, keeping in mind the challenges that present themselves when creating a curriculum?

💡: How can minoritised languages find their place in the youth's lives next to English-language TikToks and Reels in their dominant language?

Measures in Place

The [ECRML](#) entered into force in [1998](#) and has been ratified by [25 of the 46](#) States of the [Council of Europe](#). The Charter strives to **preserve and promote historical RMLs** by focusing on a language's right to exist and, as a result, it is **criticised for placing more emphasis on the languages themselves** than their speakers. It is the **only legally binding convention** in this field. However, the Charter **only defines criteria** by which an RML should be identified, **not specific languages** that meet these requirements, leaving that determination to each country.

The [RISE UP Project](#), funded by the EU, aims to support the [revitalisation](#) of endangered and minoritised languages. The project seeks to [empower](#) minoritised language communities by **connecting them with language activists and language learners** in order to facilitate and enhance an **exchange of resources**, as well as by [identifying good practices](#). The project concluded in January 2026 with a [digital toolkit](#) with **language courses**, a [language map](#), and an [album](#) and [travelling exhibition](#) of **art and music in minoritised languages**.

The [Digital Language Diversity Project](#) was a three-year project launched by [ELEN](#) in 2016 and funded by the [Erasmus+ programme](#). It aimed to **strengthen the representation of regional and minority languages online**. The project concluded with the [Digital Language Survival Kit](#), which detailed specific [recommendations](#) to improve the digital literacy of minoritised languages. It is considered to have been successful in **creating a framework to both map and measure the digital vitality of a language**, and to start to [improve](#) digital linguistic diversity.

💡: Read this [interview](#) criticising current language policies in the EU.

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

The [EU Rural Vision](#) [identifies](#) the challenges rural areas face, as well as the opportunities they present, and establishes an [action plan](#) to revitalise them. This will ultimately help endangered languages by **counterbalancing the [shift](#) to urban areas** where dominant languages are spoken. Funds such as [Erasmus+](#) and the [European Centre for Modern Languages of the Council of Europe](#) **facilitate upcoming workshops and other events** highlighting the importance of education in minoritised languages, which **continues to be [unavailable](#) in many parts of the EU**. With initiatives and frameworks such as [the RISE UP Project](#) and [The Digital Language Diversity Project](#), the EU is **counteracting the growing threat of English-dominated digitalisation** to ensure that minoritised languages have a space in the digital world that can be utilised for education and to connect speakers.

: However, is enough being done to counteract the rapid decline of minoritised language speakers?

Test your skills

Once you have read the Topic Overview, it is time for you to test your knowledge on the topic! Please complete this [short quiz](#).

Committee on Industry, Research and Energy (ITRE)

Going with the Flow: While hydroelectric plants generate 30% of all renewable energy in the EU, their potential is held back by aging infrastructure and tightening environmental constraints. How can the EU modernise and expand its hydropower sector in a way that is both sustainable and fit for the green energy transition?

by: Batu Bölükemini (TR)

Getting Started

Relevance of the Topic

For over a century, **Europe's rivers have acted as the backbone of its industrial power.** Early engineers created the hydroelectric mechanisms to turn running water into electricity long before solar panels or wind turbines emerged. Today, this technology has shifted from being the main source of energy production to being a **modern necessity to balance sustainable energy production without harming ecological systems**, following the EU's race to diminish fossil fuel usage.

Although hydroelectric energy still stands as one of the main energy sources, the aging infrastructure of such facilities in Europe **threatens its effectiveness**. More than half of the EU's operational hydroelectric plants have been in service for over forty years, with many exceeding their original design lifespans. Mitigating these threats requires **large capital investments** into comprehensive asset rehabilitation, allowing Member States to upgrade mechanical efficiency and integrate digital smart-grid technologies. While the EU has established several acts to combat this issue, their implementation and effectiveness raise concerns. To prevent the loss of this sustainable-energy source, what could the EU do?

 **Balancing Priorities:** The latest Eurostat Electricity Mix Report highlights the complexity of modern energy policy. Given this data, how should the European Commission weigh immediate grid flexibility needs against the long-term freshwater biodiversity losses caused by river fragmentation?

 **Local Mapping:** Research the primary mix of electricity generation and storage in your home country. Has your local region experienced any grid curtailment, negative pricing hours, or seasonal water scarcity that affected local power production?

Key Terms

- **Hydroelectric Plant**: A facility that generates electricity by using the force of flowing or falling water to spin turbines connected to generators. Most European plants rely on dams or river diversions to control water flow, and range from large reservoir-based stations to smaller run-of-river installations.
- **Grid Flexibility**: The power system's ability to dynamically balance electricity supply and demand in real time.
- **Digitalisation (Smart Hydro)**: The integration of modern digital technologies, such as Internet-connected sensors, predictive artificial intelligence, and automated control systems. *Smart Hydro* refers to the application of these technologies to optimise the operation, maintenance, and efficiency of hydropower facilities.
- **River Fragmentation**: The fundamental disruption of a river's natural flow and ecological pathways, primarily caused by human-made barriers such as dams. These restrict biodiversity by preventing migration of various species into these natural water transits. It also causes the species already existing in these waterways to migrate outside of the system.
- **Grid Curtailment**: The process of reducing the energy output from power generators. This is executed most commonly in wind and solar farms when renewable generation exceeds local grid transmission capacity or total consumer demand, and it is done to prevent system overloads and blackouts.

Stakeholders

- **European Commission**: The EU's executive body, responsible for proposing legislation, implementing policies, and enforcing EU law. In hydropower and energy matters, energy is a [shared competence](#) between the EU and its Member States.
- **Directorate-General for Energy (DG ENER)**: The primary department that advocates for energy-related investments. It pushes hydropower upgrades to hit Green Deal goals and is responsible for implementing RED III's fast-track permitting rules for renovating ageing plants.

- **Directorate-General for Environment (DG ENV):** Prioritises biodiversity and ecological sustainability. It oversees the Water Framework Directive and the Nature Restoration Law, both of which push Member States to restore river connectivity, which often clashes directly with DG ENER's modernisation targets.
- **Eurelectric:** Represents electricity utilities across Europe, uniting over 3,500 companies from 32 countries in power generation, distribution and supply. It advocates for streamlined infrastructure permitting and stronger investment incentives in the sector. In 2025, it joined the International Hydropower Association ([IHA](#)) in a joint call urging the Commission to prioritise pumped-storage hydropower in EU energy strategy due to its scalability and [cost-effective operations](#).
- **European Association for Storage of Energy (EASE):** The largest association in Europe that advocates for energy market rules and focuses on upgrading existing plants to include pumped hydro storage. In 2025, it also joined the IHA joint call.
- **European Network of Transmission System Operators for Electricity (ENTSO-E):** The association of Europe's 40 transmission system operators, responsible for coordinating grid stability and publishing the Ten-Year Network Development Plan ([TYNDP](#)).
- **European Environmental Bureau (EEB):** Represents the NGOs that advocate for environmental protection. The organisation [opposes expanding hydroelectric plants](#) due to the damage these plants cause to rivers and biodiversity. It also proposes removing dams and focusing on alternative energy sources. It is an active member of the [Dam Removal Europe](#) coalition, which campaigns for removing obsolete barriers to help meet the Nature Restoration Law's [target of reconnecting 25,000 km of free-flowing rivers by 2030](#).

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

Ecological impact vs. Green energy targets

The main dilemma this committee faces is how to address the challenge of ageing hydroelectric plants while protecting ecological balance and river systems. Over the past century, [large-scale hydropower has helped Europe achieve industrial growth](#), delivering **reliable electricity** and **creating grid stability** along the continent.

However, implementing such infrastructural improvements comes with the risk of severely **disrupting the [natural balance of the rivers](#)**, which are essential in [preserving ecological sustainability and biodiversity](#). For centuries, these waterways have existed as natural corridors and have been essential for [local ecosystems](#) and migratory species. Today, the prevalence of dams and hydroelectric plants has **fragmented** these natural corridors. Although these dams help Europe generate [carbon-free electricity and ensure grid resilience](#), they [disrupt the natural sediment flow](#) of these rivers and **severely alter long-established river-dependent ecosystems**. These disruptions are a direct result of this infrastructure's presence.

Legislative contradiction: RED III vs. Water Framework Directive

Another layer of conflict comes from the EU's legislation **contradicting itself**. The [Renewable Energy Directive](#) requires the Member States to expand and modernise their hydropower capacity to **meet renewable energy targets**. At the same time, the [Water Framework Directive](#) encourages these Member States to restore their rivers to "good ecological status," which may involve **removing old dams**. This creates confusion for national governments, which often [remain unsure](#) how to reconcile these obligations at the same time.. Consequently, this uncertainty ends up [affecting](#) how individual hydropower projects get approved or rejected on a local level.

Investment priorities: Renovation vs. Renewable expansion

Beyond the ecological dimension, there is also an **economic conflict** at play. [Renovating old hydroelectric plants requires massive capital investment](#), but national budgets are already being pulled towards other [green energy priorities](#) such as [wind and solar expansion](#).

Eurelectric and similar utility groups [argue that faster permits and stronger investment incentives](#) are needed to make these renovation projects **financially viable** for Member States. Conversely, [environmental organisations worry](#) that expediting these procedures could **weaken the environmental checks** that are supposed to protect river ecosystems from further damage.

⚡ : Who decides what?: *If the Renewable Energy Directive and the Water Framework Directive point national governments in opposite directions, who gets the right to have the final say?*

⚡ : Paying for modernisation: *Should EU funding prioritise renovating existing hydropower plants over building new renewable capacity, even if that means slower growth in solar and wind?*

Measures in Place

The [Renewable Energy Directive \(RED III\)](#) is one of the most significant components when it comes to **legislative climate measures**. It classifies hydropower as a technology of "[overriding public interest](#)", meaning Member States are pushed to [fast-track permits for refurbishing old plants](#) through designated renewables acceleration areas. In theory, this should have sped things up, but as of late 2025, most Member States [still hadn't fully implemented](#) the permitting rules into their national law, so the Commission actually had to [open infringement](#) procedures **against several** of them.

From a more **environmental perspective**, the [Nature Restoration Law](#) sets a target to reconnect at least 25,000 km of EU rivers by 2030 by removing obsolete barriers, such as dams, potentially creating tensions with policies aimed at keeping these structures running. Moreover, the [Water Framework Directive](#) adds another layer, requiring "**good ecological status**" for rivers. This is often [interpreted differently by authorities](#) depending on whether they lean towards **energy security or biodiversity**.

In terms of **funding**, instruments like the [LIFE Programme](#) and various [Cohesion Fund allocations](#) have supported river-connectivity and fish-passage projects, but [critics argue](#) the money going into modernising **ageing hydropower infrastructure** itself is still insufficient to meet the demand.

As a collection of all these measures in place, here are two examples of national initiatives that show a **middle path** between effective energy production and environmental care:

Sweden: [Sweden's National Plan for Modern Environmental Conditions](#) is relicensing roughly 2,000 hydropower plants over 20 years to add fish passages and environmental flow rules, backed by a €900 million industry-funded Hydroelectric Environmental Fund that covers up to 85% of operators' compliance costs.

France: [France's "list 2" river classification](#) legally obliges dam owners on designated rivers to install fish passages and allow sediment flow within five years, rather than removing the dam outright, showing how retrofit requirements can restore river connectivity without shutting down production.

 **Funding Gaps:** *With critics arguing that LIFE Programme and Cohesion Fund support for hydropower modernisation is still insufficient, which priorities should EU funding focus on to ensure both ecological sustainability and the long-term viability of hydropower?*

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

Looking ahead, the European Commission is currently working on a [draft renewable energy framework for the post-2030 era](#). This could finally offer specific sustainability criteria for hydropower. It is expected to increase interest in “[smart hydro](#)” using AI and sensors to catch various issues in plants. This could help reduce the [growing pressure](#) on whether dam removal should move faster than reconstruction.

Another key aspect to keep an eye on is [pumped-storage-based hydropower](#), as it is increasingly seen as the **backbone of grid flexibility** while wind and solar energy sectors expand. This means that old reservoirs could potentially [get a second chance](#) as larger-scale batteries, rather than being framed as just power generators.

 **Second life for reservoirs:** *Should old hydropower reservoirs be repurposed primarily as large-scale batteries for wind and solar, rather than kept as power generators in their own right?*

Committee on Legal Affairs (JURI)

Killing the puppets: With corporations spending €380 million annually on lobbying the EU and watchdog organisations speaking out against the apparent lack of transparency in some European institutions, concerns over corporate influence on policy-making continue to grow. In view of this, how should the EU work with outside organisations to create a Union where democratic processes are respected and valued?

by: Alba Tenesa Navarro (UK)

Getting Started

Starter Pack



Relevance of the Topic

Lobbying is an [integral part](#) of the EU's governance, allowing businesses, NGOs, trade associations, and other stakeholders to contribute their expertise, evidence, and practical knowledge to the policymaking process. However, in recent years, lobbying activity has expanded significantly, with [concerns growing surrounding](#) whether corporate interests are gaining **disproportionate influence** over **democratic decision-making**. According to [Corporate Europe Observatory](#) and [LobbyControl](#), the largest industry associations now spend **€382 million annually** lobbying EU institutions, a **50% increase from 2020**. The highest-spending sectors include Big Tech, Energy, Chemicals, and Agri-business. Big Tech alone spends around **€73 million annually** on EU lobbying, led by **Meta** and **Amazon**, which displayed a **414.3% rise since 2020**. This surge alone illustrates the dramatic increase in their declared lobbying budgets.

These developments coincide with **one of the largest deregulation drives in EU history**, as the European Commission proposes a series of omnibus packages aimed at [simplifying existing legislation](#). Watchdog organisations [warn](#) that weak transparency rules, a voluntary lobbying register, and limited enforcement mechanisms allow corporations to **exert significant influence** while providing incomplete or inaccurate information about their activities.



Figure 1: Illustration displaying the breakdown of sectors' spending on lobbying

Key Terms

- **Transparency:** When businesses or organisations act in a way that is open, honest, and clear, sharing information freely.

- **Democratic accountability**: The principle that those in power have a responsibility to act in the public's best interest.
- **Conflict of interest**: A situation in which someone has competing interests that could influence their professional obligations.
- **Regulatory capture**: A process where a regulatory agency, instead of acting in the public's best interest, benefits a dominant leader in the industry.
- **Revolving doors**: When an individual or thing continuously returns to the same state, behaviour or issue despite repeated attempts to move forward. Creating a continuous cycle of repetition rather than sustained progress or change.

Stakeholders

- **The Council of the EU**: A key EU decision-making institution that brings together ministers from each of the 27 Member States to adopt EU laws, coordinate policies, and adopt the EU budget. Working alongside the [European Parliament](#), the Council helps shape and adopt legislation on lobbying transparency, ethics and democratic governance, including through its participation in the [Interinstitutional Agreement](#).
- **Directorate-General for Justice and Consumers (DG JUST)**: a European Commission department responsible for upholding the rule of law, protecting fundamental rights, and strengthening democratic governance within the EU. In the context of lobbying and corporate influence, DG JUST develops and implements policies that promote transparency, accountability, and ethical standards. These policies aim to ensure that interactions between EU institutions and external organisations respect democratic values and the rule of law. The EU has [shared competence](#) in this matter, meaning that the EU and Member States both have the power to legislate and adopt legally binding acts.
- **The European Ombudsman**: an independent and impartial body that investigates complaints about maladministration¹ by European Union Institutions, bodies, and agencies. It can either launch complaints on its own accord or as a result of a citizen of an EU Member State, a resident of an EU country, or an organisation filing a complaint.
- **Lobbying Organisations**: Organisations or groups that attempt to influence someone in authority to support a public policy or legislation. They represent

¹ **Maladministration** refers to either unfair conduct, discrimination, abuse of power, refusal to provide information or unnecessary delays due to incorrect procedures

businesses, industries, NGOs, trade unions, or consumer groups. For example, technology companies may lobby EU institutions about the [EU AI Act](#), while consumers and civil society groups may advocate for stronger protections and transparency.

- **[Watchdog Organisations](#):** independent groups or non-profit organisations that monitor the activities of governments, corporations, or other institutions. Their primary goal is to ensure transparency, accountability, and ethical behaviour. Watchdog organisations can vary in their types; different types include: Consumer Watchdogs, Corporate Watchdogs, Government Watchdogs, Advertising Watchdogs and Charity Watchdogs.
- **Non-governmental organisations (NGOs):** Are nonprofit entities that operate independently of the government, although many receive funding from governments or public institutions such as the EU. The main aim for NGOs is to advocate for social change by influencing policies and legislation. For example, [EU Watchdog Radio](#) is a podcast led by NGOs, [Counter Balance](#) and Corporate Europe Observatory, both Brussels-based. They discuss topics surrounding how to improve transparency or how to align EU policies more with public interest.

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

Balancing democratic participation with transparency is a key challenge in lobbying. Lobbying plays a [significant role](#) in EU democracy, as it enables businesses, NGOs, and trade associations to contribute their expertise and evidence in the policymaking process. However, finding the line between keeping it transparent, fair, and democratic can be difficult. [The Treaty of Lisbon](#) requires institutions to **maintain an open and regular dialogue** with organisations; although there are difficulties with maintaining public confidence whilst remaining faithful to this principle. Excessive transparency requirements may **discourage engagement** or create administrative burdens, whereas insufficient transparency can make it difficult for citizens to understand **who is influencing policy decisions**, raising concerns about [undue influence, unequal competition, and potential corruption](#) within lobbying.

: How do you think the EU can reach an effective balance between ensuring transparency in lobbying and encouraging broad democratic participation?

Furthermore, **disproportionate corporate influence** is another key dilemma in EU lobbying. Larger corporations often have [substantially greater financial resources](#) than NGOs, consumer groups, and smaller stakeholders, enabling them to **invest heavily in lobbying** and maintaining frequent engagement with EU policymakers. [Supporters argue](#) that large companies provide valuable technical expertise and practical knowledge, particularly in complex sectors such as technology and energy, which can make policymaking more effective. However, [critics contend](#) that this financial advantage can create **unequal access to decision-makers** and result in corporate interests often being **more strongly represented**. For example, major technology companies like Meta [have lobbied](#) against aspects of the [Digital Services Act](#), [AI Act](#), and the [General Data Protection Regulation](#), raising concerns that well-resourced industries may exert disproportionate influence over the development of EU legislation.

: How can the EU ensure that smaller NGOs and citizen groups have the same opportunity to influence policy as multinational corporations?

The **risk of regulatory capture and weakened legislation** is another significant conflict. Companies and organisations play an important role in helping policymakers [understand the practical and economic impacts](#) of proposed legislation. However, critics have argued that when industries lobby to weaken rules that directly affect their own operations, there is a [risk of weakened enforcement and policies](#) that increasingly **reflect private rather than public interest**. For example, while major technology companies have campaigned against various regulatory acts, energy companies have been [accused of using recent geopolitical crises](#) to fight for deregulation and **continued investment in fossil fuels**.

: Should companies be allowed to lobby against regulations that directly affect their profits? Why or why not?

Measures in Place

The EU Transparency Register (EUTR) is a public database that records organisations and individuals who seek to influence EU policy-making and decision-making through lobbying. It was originally established by the European Parliament and the European Commission in 2011, with the Council of the EU joining under the revised [2021 Interinstitutional Agreement](#). The register aims to increase transparency by allowing citizens to see who is lobbying EU institutions, whose interests they represent, what policy areas they seek to influence and basic financial information about their lobbying activities. However, despite improving transparency surrounding lobbying, [critics have argued it is limited](#) as it does not capture all

lobbying activities, applies rules inconsistently across EU institutions, lacks strong enforcement mechanisms, and suffers from data quality.

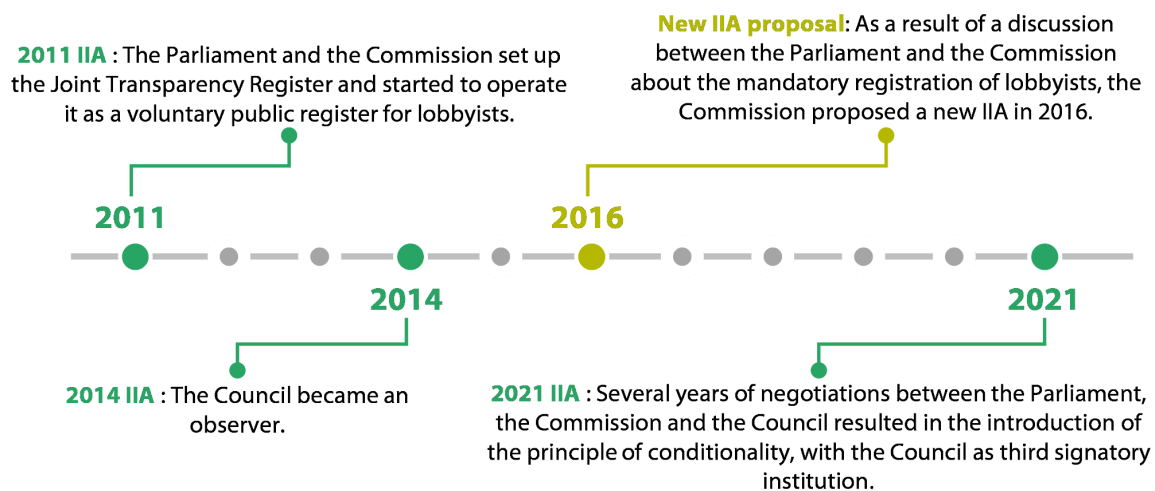


Figure 2: *Timeline of the EUTR (self-made)*

Regulation (EC) No 1049/2001 of the European Parliament is an important EU transparency measure that gives citizens and organisations the right to access documents held by the European Parliament, the Council of the EU, and the European Commission. Its purpose is to make EU decision-making more open and accountable. However, this right of access is not unlimited: documents can be withheld or partially redacted to protect public security, privacy, and commercial interests.

European Anti-Fraud Office - is an independent body that investigates fraud, corruption, and financial misconduct involving EU funds and institutions. Its role is primarily administrative, meaning that it investigates irregularities rather than acting as a criminal prosecution service. OLAF works closely with the [European Public Prosecutor's Office](#), particularly where cases may involve criminal offences affecting the EU budget.

 : *Research in more depth the successes and failures of these measures and create a poster to display your findings. When doing this task, do not just focus on the current measures in place; brainstorm measures you would like to implement!*

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

Looking ahead, the future of lobbying in the European Union is likely to focus on **increasing transparency** whilst ensuring that all stakeholders can **participate fairly** in the policymaking process. Potential reforms include strengthening the [EU Transparency Register](#), **improving disclosure requirements**, and introducing stricter rules on **revolving doors** to reduce conflicts of interest. However, the **growing use of artificial intelligence** and online campaigning may create new challenges for transparency and accountability.

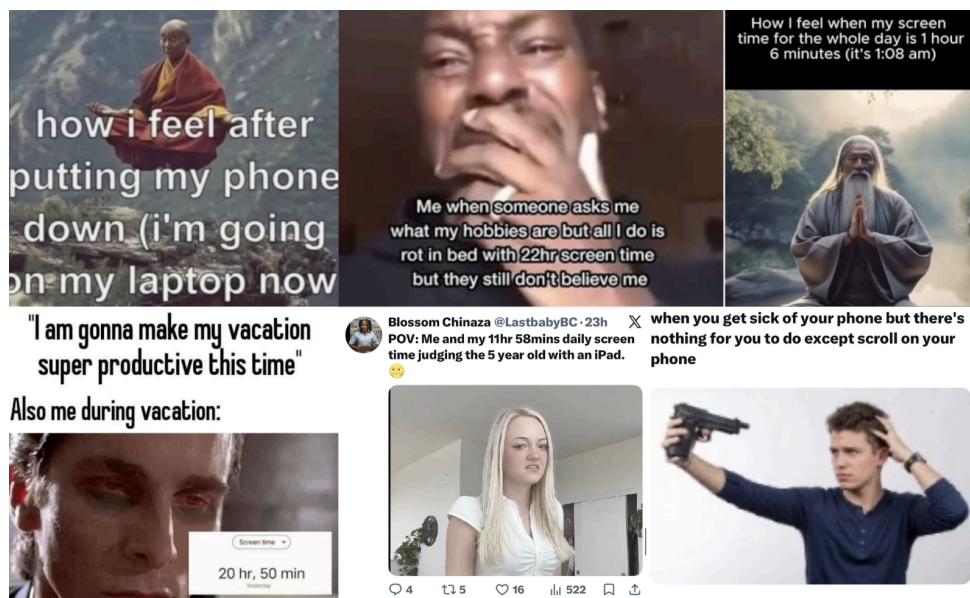
Committee on Civil Liberties, Justice and Home Affairs (LIBE)

Swipe Fatigue: As concerns grow over the impact of digital dependency and excessive screen time on young people's mental health and social development, these habits are increasingly shaping how younger generations interact with the world around them. How can the EU promote healthier digital habits whilst encouraging meaningful engagement with local communities, cultures and traditions?

by: Carolina Andrade (PT)

Getting Started

Starter Pack



Relevance of the Topic

European societies are becoming [increasingly dependent](#) on multinational platform companies, such as Google, Amazon, Meta and Apple. This dependence is increasingly perceived as problematic by governments, civil society organisations, and citizens alike, as it puts a strain on public values such as **safety** and **democratic freedoms**.

Between 2018 and 2022, the number of adolescents showing **signs of problematic social media use** rose from [11% to 7%, and 12%](#) are at **risk of problematic gaming** such as **excessive screen use**. More than [one in three young people](#) report being in **constant online**

contact with friends, leading to **long-term health outcomes**. These habits are full of risks on health: **excessive screen use** can **disrupt sleep**, **reduce physical activity**, and **alter brain development** in ways that **increase** internalising problems such as **anxiety** and **depression**. Thus, digital dependency can reshape **how young people interact offline**, potentially **weakening face-to-face social skills** and peer support.

Europe calls for **digital literacy education**, **mental health services**, and **platform accountability** because, according to the [World Health Organisation](#), [current responses are inadequate](#) and often lag behind technological change. This makes the issue not only clinical but also political and ethical.

The [EU urges](#) to ensure that digital environments support healthy development, protect vulnerable users, and preserve the social spaces where democratic participation, community ties, and cultural belonging are formed. In this sense, the question is not only [how the EU can promote healthier digital habits](#), but also how it can help young people remain meaningfully connected to local communities, cultures, and traditions in an age dominated by platform-based communication.

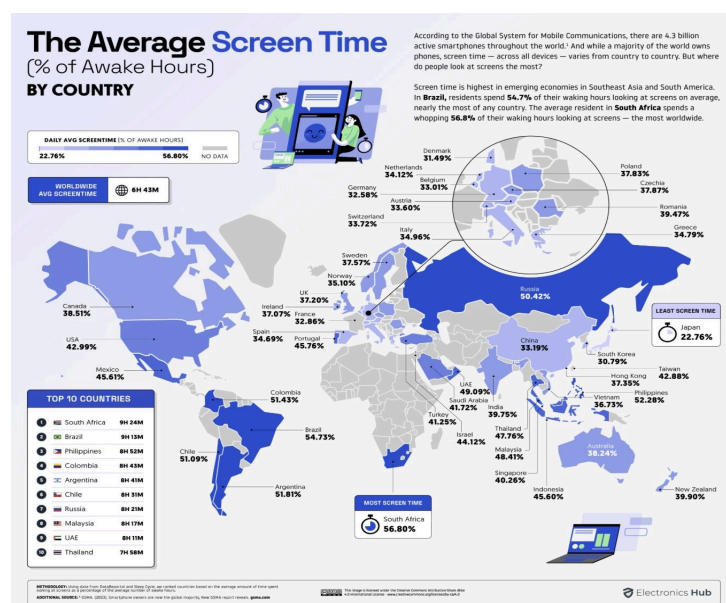


Figure 1: The average screen time by country

Key Terms

- **Single Dominant Provider:** refers to a business or organisation that controls the vast majority of a specific market, functioning either as a near-monopoly or an entity with massive pricing and operational independence from smaller competitors, and

therefore able to behave to an appreciable extent independently of its competitors, customers, and ultimately consumers.

- **Digital Literacy**: ability to use information and communication technologies to find, critically assess, create, and communicate information, requiring both cognitive and technical skills.
- **Very Large Online Platforms (VLOPs) and Search Engines**: are those with over 45 million users in the EU. They must comply with the most stringent rules of the DSA.
- **Digital Independence**: the ability of individuals, organisations, or governments to control their own digital data, IT infrastructure, and technology without relying on, or being restricted by, single dominant providers or foreign powers.

 : How can the EU motivate young generations to find interest in other activities which do not involve screens?

Stakeholders

- **European Commission's Directorate-General for Communications Networks, Content and Technology (DG CONNECT)**: develops and implements EU digital policies, including the regulation of online platforms and the protection of minors online. Interested in creating a safer, fairer, and more accountable digital environment while supporting digital innovation and Europe's digital transformation.
- **European Commission's Directorate-General for Education, Youth, Sport and Culture (DG EAC)**: works on education, youth participation, sport, and cultural policies that can provide alternatives to excessive digital engagement. Aims to promote inclusive education, youth participation, cultural diversity, and engagement with local communities and European culture.
- **European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights (FRA)**: provides research and evidence on fundamental rights, including children's rights, privacy, and the effects of the digital environment. Seeks to ensure that digital policies respect human rights and protect children and young people from potential harms.
- **World Health Organisation (WHO)**: provides international research and guidance concerning mental health, physical activity, children's well-being, and healthy lifestyles. Aims to improve public health and reduce health risks associated with unhealthy lifestyles and potentially problematic digital behaviours.
- **Directorate-General for Health and Food Safety (DG SANTE)**: is responsible for EU policies concerning public health and health protection. Its main interest is to protect

and improve public health across the EU. In relation to young people's digital habits, its aims can include promoting mental well-being, preventing health risks, supporting healthy lifestyles, and ensuring that public health policies are based on scientific evidence.

- **VLOPs and VLOSEs** (Meta, X, TikTok, Google, etc.): are both the space where disinformation spreads and the actors responsible for moderating it. Their business models rely on engagement-driven algorithms, which can unintentionally amplify harmful content. Their cooperation with EU authorities is crucial for making regulations like the Digital Services Act ([DSA](#)) effective.

Inside the Topic



[Illustration 1](#): "Now that I have your undivided attention..." by Mark Lynch (2020)

Key Conflicts

Health Issues vs. Digital Opportunities

One of the most discussed conflicts among stakeholders is the **duality of social media**, being harmful and beneficial to health. [9 out of 10](#) EU adolescents report at least one **negative symptom linked to screen use**, such as tired eyes, headaches, concentration problems, and poorer eating. [Nearly 1 in 3](#) EU adolescents feel **stressed, sad, or socially excluded** for causes related to social media, and 45% **compare themselves to others**. Furthermore, a [large number of adolescents](#) face problematic, misleading or harmful content online such as: hate speech; promotion of unhealthy products such as alcohol or unhealthy food; pressure on how to look or what to buy; or pressure to follow certain body standards.

However, on the other hand, [48% of EU teens](#) see social media as a **positive influence** on their **mental wellbeing**, mainly for entertainment, connection with friends/family, and even Europe notes that [non-problematic heavy users](#) can report **stronger peer support** and **social connections**.

 : For further understanding, check [this article](#) about “The hazards of excessive screen time: Impacts on physical health, mental health, and overall well-being”, and [this Harvard article](#) “Screen Time and the Brain”.

Online Engagement vs. Offline Political and Civic Participation

Community Participation is also a pressing issue. Young people are more likely than the general population to **engage with civic and political issues online** (e.g. expressing opinions, taking part in online consultations), highlighting a shift toward **digitised forms of participation** and raising questions about whether this substitutes or complements local and offline involvement. In 2025, [24.3%](#) of young Europeans aged 16 to 29 engaged in civic or political issues online. This includes **expressing their opinion on civic or political issues** or **taking part in online consultations or voting**. In comparison, this type of engagement was only [20.2%](#) among the overall population.

Besides that, this [online engagement](#) is often “thin” and **episodic, centred on visibility and individual expression**, while **offline participation** tends to be “thicker”, based on **long-term relationships, shared practices and local belonging—raising concerns** that political interest and activism are becoming increasingly detached from concrete communities and everyday democratic institutions.

The “Digital Vulnerability” Divide

Finally, about Equity and Digital Division, another pressing issue is the **unevenly distributed excessive screen time** and its harms; [vulnerable groups](#) may face both higher exposure and fewer protective resources from screen exposure. Young people [are not all equally exposed to digital harm](#): the most vulnerable tend to be younger children, adolescents with limited digital literacy or weaker cognitive ability to judge risk, and those already facing offline disadvantages such as mental health conditions, low family support, poverty, disability, or marginalisation.

Early social media entry (before age 10) is [linked to much higher weekend screen time](#) (7.5 vs. 5.7 hours per weekend for those who start after age 14). The European Parliament and the European Commission [have highlighted](#) how digitalisation can **create social differences** in access to devices and connectivity, skills such as **operational skills**,

information-navigation skills, and outcomes like **cyberbullying**, **privacy violations**, **online risk exposure**, **stress**, or **lower well-being**. Previous research has found that [problematic social media users](#) also reported lower mental and social well-being and higher levels of substance use compared to non-problematic users and non-users, which may contribute to existing social **inequalities**. The policies that restrict access or time [may penalise disadvantaged youths](#) who rely on digital tools for learning and social connection, while failing to address underlying vulnerabilities.

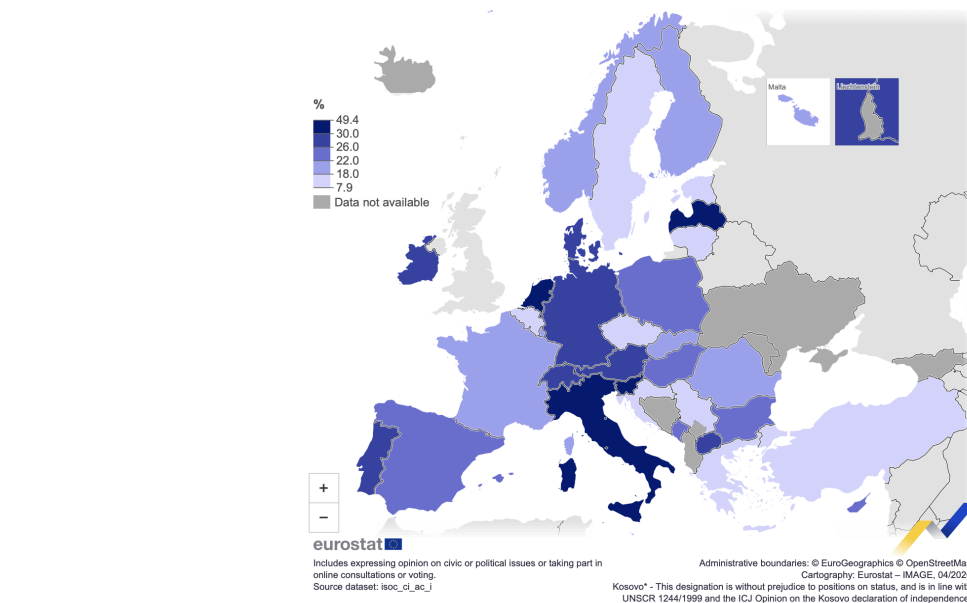


Figure 2: *Young people who used the internet for civic or political participation, Eurostat, 2025*



Illustration 2: *Hi, My Name Is Amanda and I Haven't Looked at My Phone for 58 Seconds", by Mark Lynch (2012)*

Measures in Place

Since 2024, the [DSA](#) is fully applicable in all EU countries and [imposes legal obligations](#) on VLOPs and search engines. The DSA explicitly **bans** targeted advertising based on profiling for children. Platforms must systematically **assess and mitigate risks to minors'** physical and mental health, including risks related to addictive design, cyberbullying, and harmful content, while also ensuring that their services are safe and age-appropriate.

This includes [default settings](#) that **protect minors** and limit exposure to harmful or addictive content, and providing information on how their recommender systems¹ work, enabling scrutiny and potential regulatory action against harmful or overly addictive content. National Digital Services Coordinators and the European Commission can **impose [fines up to 6% of global turnover](#)** and, in extreme cases, order **temporary bans** of services that repeatedly violate the rules, including those harming minors.

Another measure in place is the EU's [Better Internet for Kids Plus](#) (BIK+), which works through three concrete pillars: **safe digital experiences, digital empowerment, and active participation**. It aims to protect **children** from harmful online content and risks, **build their digital literacy** and **decision-making skills**, and give them **a voice in shaping safer digital spaces**. It also operates through the EU-funded Safer Internet Centres network, the [Better Internet for Kids](#) portal with resources in all EU languages, and child-led evaluations of the strategy every two years. BIK is also tied to existing EU actions that make it more effective.

The strategy is linked to the [DSA](#), which includes **safeguards for minors** and **bans profiling-based targeted ads to children**, and it **supports work on age verification, faster assessment of illegal or harmful content, and anti-cyberbullying measures**, including the [Action Plan against Cyberbullying](#).

 : *Should platforms have the final say in the screen time on young people? Or should the parents?*

¹ A [recommender system](#), or in the context of social media, simply algorithm is a type of information filtering system that suggests items most relevant to a particular user.

Further Understanding

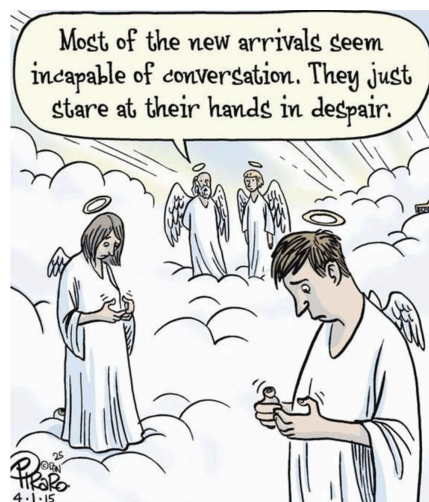


Illustration 3: "Bizarro" by Dan Piraro (2015)

Pillars of the Future

In the coming years, the topic will likely evolve from a concern about “too much screen time” to a more complex challenge: how to design **digital environments, education systems, and local communities** that support both technological fluency and rich offline lives. In this developing society, it is **difficult to stop technology and new ideas**. The EU’s future role will depend on its ability to **coordinate across policy areas, involve young people in designing solutions**, and **balance regulation with innovation**. If successful, digital dependency could become a catalyst for new forms of civic and cultural engagement; if not, it may deepen existing inequalities and further erode trust in both digital and public institutions.

Test your skills

To test your skills and see if you are prepared for this session, try to do [this](#) Kahoot!



: For further information about this topic check these videos:

- [“How smartphone addiction may be hurting our brains”](#), by CBS Evening News
- [“Screen Time \(A Short Film\)”](#), by Isaac Burke
- [“Social Media addiction - Short Movie”](#)

Committee on Regional Development (REGI)

Cultural Renaissance: *As many European regions face economic decline, rural depopulation and the loss of traditional cultural practices, local arts and culture can be increasingly promoted as tools for regional revitalisation. How can the EU use local arts and culture to revitalise regions without compromising sustainability and cultural authenticity?*

by: Tao Tulga (CY)

Getting Started

Starter Pack



Relevance of the Topic

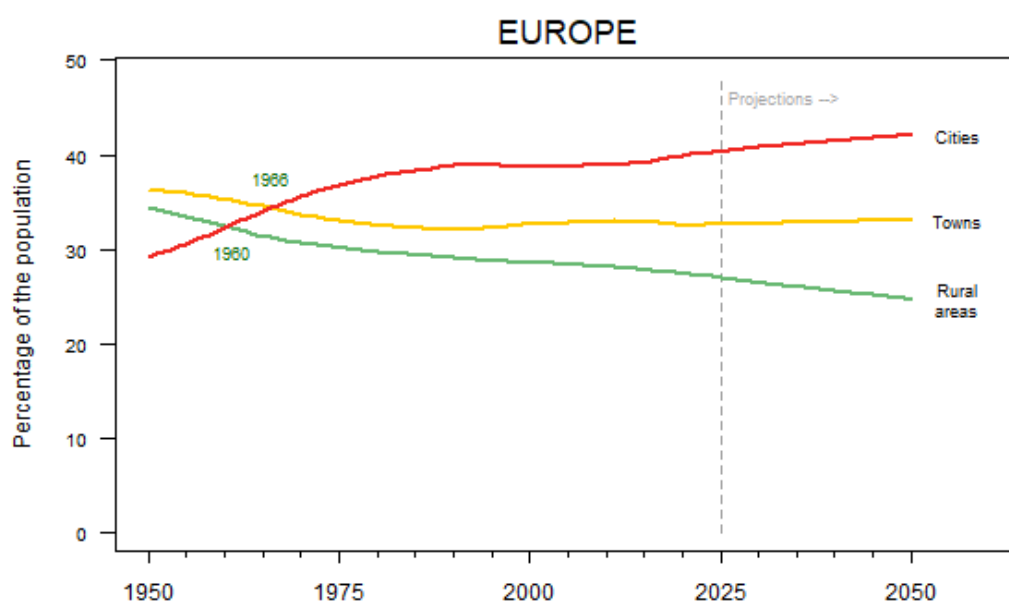
Our roots, up to our grandparents' period, reside predominantly in rural identities; in fact, up to the 1950s, [only 30% of European people](#) lived in Urban centres. Prior to the 19th century, national identity in the modern sense was largely absent; instead, people would be named

after the [town or province they were from](#), as seen through the names of artists such as Veronese, revealing how **civic** and **regional identities** used to **supersede the national**, until the [rise of Nationalism and Centralisation in the 19th century](#). Regional identities were reproduced through **cultural practices**, expressed through local arts, which established traditions exclusive to regions that people identified with. These traditions often became manifested in **economic practices** and **vocations**, aiming to offer something unique which provided a means of sustenance for regions. [The loss of these traditions and local practices has coincided with economic decline in regions](#); hence their revival is essential for regional prosperity.

Peripherisation has contributed to [depopulation and economic decline in many regional areas](#). Primarily a product of globalisation, which prioritises [global production networks, impersonal economic relations, and populous office blocks](#), putting individual regions at a significant disadvantage. As a result, the youth move to Urban centres in order to **build careers and find opportunities**. Despite the benefits of urban life, it is important to revitalise regions, as Europe thrives on diversity, apparent in its motto “*united in diversity*”. While it is unlikely for regions to economically compete with their urban counterparts, they can prevail in culture, art, and authenticity; hence an emphasis on these sectors can prove to be a fundamental lifeline for regions.

Activity: If you come from an Urban Centre (big city), ask your Grandparents or Parents about where your family comes from, as many grandparents or a few generations down moved from villages or towns.

Percentage of population living in cities, towns and rural areas:



© 2025 United Nations, DESA, Population Division. Licensed under Creative Commons license CC BY 3.0 IGO. United Nations, DESA, Population Division. *World Urbanization Prospects 2025*. <https://population.un.org/wup/>

Figure 1: *UN survey of European habitation demographic*

Key Terms

- **Regionalism**: identifying with a region, as opposed to a wider pan-regional national entity. From a political lens, it tends to call for increased regional autonomy and devolution.
- **Peripherisation**: the process where certain groups, regions, or social classes are pushed to the edges of power
- **Regional Revitalisation**: to give new life, energy, activity, or success to Regions
- **Modernity** and **Traditionalism**: Modernity refers to the movement which accepts individualism, urbanisation, and rationality as the inherent path forward. While Traditionalism is the opposite of Modernity, holding onto folk traditions, emphasises communities over the individual; rationality is much less inherent.
- **Cultural authenticity**- the degree to which practices, expressions, or artefacts are true to their original roots.

Stakeholders

- **Regional Governments**: Central political entities which govern regions, such as: Generalitat de Catalunya (Spain), which controls services such as healthcare, police, and culture. Åland Islands Government (Finland), which has its own parliament and local taxation. Regione Veneto (Italy), an ordinary region which is allowed regional planning and some legislative power.
- **Regional language bodies**: Institutions which aim to preserve regional languages, Euskaltzaindia (Basque), Foras na Ghaeilge (Irish). They work on making the languages functional, such as adapting terms to fit science, business, etc. The bodies tend to organise festivals and different ways to immerse in the language.
- **Regional communities**: These communities sit at the heart of regions, holding the capacity to voice local concerns, organise cultural events, and reproduce culture. Often representing Regional Artisans who shape the culture, art, and identity of regions. Such artisans include ceramicists, glassmakers, ironmongers, etc.
- **Directorate-General for Regional and Urban Policy (DG REGIO)** and **Directorate-General for Education, Youth, Sport and Culture (DG EAC)**: branches

of the European Commission, comparable to national ministries. DG REGIO supports the economic and social development of all regions of the European Union through investment. While DG EAC promotes culture through youth and sporting ventures.

- **[European Committee of the Regions](#)**: it represents local and regional authorities across the European Union and advises on new laws that have an impact on regions and cities.
- **[European Investment Bank](#)**: it provides funding for regional projects, through loans and expertise for sustainable infrastructure, climate action, and economic development.

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

The main issue is how to harness the **virtues of modernity** while preserving **traditions** and **culture** in regions. Modernity has paved the way for advanced medicine, centralised schooling, raised literacy rates, and increased standards of living through urban imports, such as electricity, public transport, etc.

A clear example is the conflict facing **artisans: those** not adapting to the modern ways of industrial production **often remain economically uncompetitive** due to their traditional means of production, which shapes the ethos of their craft, resulting in goods [driving them out of a living](#). At the same time, others choose to adapt to industrial production means, allowing them to cater to a wider consumer base, though at times resulting in loss of [traditional practices](#). Meanwhile, some artisans prefer to maintain their practices and market their goods as a luxury to a more niche clientele. The main conflict is how to **adapt production methods while preserving authentic artisanal quality**, while also handling the [popular disposable culture](#), which is not willing to pay extra for artisanry.

Another conflict resides in [digital institutions](#), such as streaming and social media platforms, **dominating traditional ones**, such as theatres, pubs, and ballrooms, which all foster a sense of community and a centre to showcase local art forms. Despite appearing as conflicting institutions, it is possible for digital systems to be used as a platform to promote tangible art forms. This can be seen, for example, in EU bodies such as [Europeana](#), which provides Artisans with a platform to promote their crafts, and in media influencers increasingly promoting art forms such as Ballet, Opera, and Theatre.

Over the past century, history has been vastly manipulated in order to fit a national image; therefore, it is important to read between the lines, holding on to primordial rural histories, while also integrating the modern history which has developed since. This means recognising, for instance, how the [Italian national language](#) taught in schools is based on the Florentine dialect, or how every town once had its [own variation of folk dress](#), respecting the culture which has developed since, yet not losing sight of what lay before, a past largely shaped by regional communities. The conflict is not which path should survive, but how we can make them intersect, to **create a bower of modern virtue** which meanwhile **preserves the traditional and communal flavours**.

Youth is a necessity for **revitalising regions, keeping them relevant**, and **reproducing their cultural identity**. The conflict is how to encourage the youth to stay in, or move to regions, while big cities offer them increased career prospects and sustainable lives.

🎨: *Make a list of 3 modern virtues, and 3 regional traditional virtues, then attempt to note down how one of each modern and traditional virtue could coexist in a community.*



Figure 2: Celebration of European Heritage Day in Lithuania

Measures in Place

Creative Europe Programme - It is a European Commission programme; it serves as a transnational scheme to safeguard, develop, and **promote cultural and linguistic diversity and heritage**. Trying to give regional or smaller-scale sectors a platform for economic competitiveness and to raise their potential. Targets funding, providing mobility, and aid to artists to expand their audience. It has been efficient and beneficial on a transnational scale, allowing organisations to expand their audience to a Pan-European platform. However, it is limited to registered organisations, and it is also unlikely small scale regional organisations or

individual artisans would find this scheme or be recognised for it.

European Regional Development Fund - It aims to fund **regional development**, contributing to the betterment of rural regions, helping them to be more digitalised, competitive, and urbanly developed, while aiming to boost social life through increased **centralised education**, and funding **cultural tourism**. Though these policies economically benefit rural regions, they come at the cost of culture and tradition, as a digitised life and tourism-catered jobs weaken local identity rather than foster it.

LEADER/CLLD - These are European Union methods used to help local communities **design** and run **their own development strategies**. They provide funding to rural communities to preserve their art forms; they are seen in Cyprus with subsidising pottery, copperware, and traditional walking sticks. It allows local communities to decide where to allocate the money, which is very successful in bypassing bureaucracy. This scheme greatly **supports material culture**, reproducing intangible culture in hand.

: *Research what LEADER/CLLD was spent on in your area, which local crafts it helped support, and anything it could have potentially missed, contemplating why, if so?*

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

In an age where people question the virtues of urban life, one lens to explore is the regional and rural. Regional communities have begun to push for **increased autonomy**, seeing strong movements from regions such as Catalonia, which have called for the EU to recognise their language as an official EU language. Numerous groups are calling for increased recognition, such as the Bretons and Frisians.

Would it be impossible for one to outline a future Europe of Regions? Or, as opposed to nation states, an increasingly federalised structure? Perhaps instead a rise in PanRegionalism, or on the other hand fragmentation, the rise of these questions leaves Europe at a potential crossroads.

The European Union is progressively investing more in the regions; at the same time, their voices get louder, along with their call for **preservation of culture** and **traditions**.

Committee on Security and Defence (SEDE)

Standing Guard: As global conflicts escalate and the reliability of long-standing alliances such as NATO increasingly comes into question, the EU finds itself exposed by decades of underinvestment in defence and an over-reliance on external security guarantees. In view of this, how can the EU strengthen its shared defence policy and foster cooperation between Member States to ensure its own security and strategic autonomy?

by: Emma Belleri (IT)

Getting Started

Starter Pack



Relevance of the Topic

The long-standing **cooperation** between [the EU and NATO](#), which aims to **safeguard** the **freedom** and **security** of their respective members, has played a key role in ensuring **collective defence**. However, recent questions have arisen about its effectiveness,

particularly after growing **uncertainty** about the [US long-term commitment](#) to Europe's security and collective defence. Furthermore, the post-Cold War **reduction** in **military defence spending** and the decision to **outsource** military resources to external political powers, such as the US, with [75% of EU defence sourcing still going to non-EU suppliers](#), have left Europe in a security **struggle**. This dependence has carried [concrete strategic risks](#), like **less strategic autonomy**, **supply chain vulnerability** and a **fragmented European industry**.

To tackle these issues, in the last few years, different [strategies have been implemented by the European Commission](#) to strengthen the EU's military system and build a "European Defence Union". These measures have resulted in a significant increase in defence **expenditures**, with [€343 billion in 2024](#): an increase of [43% since 2021](#) and projected to reach [€392 billion in 2025–2026](#). The establishment of a **common defence policy** across the EU has also been limited by the fact that defence remains a **national competence**, under [Art. 4\(2\) TEU](#), highlighting divergent defence strategies, driven by [different perceptions of threats](#) between European countries.

 : Do you think it is fair to call the EU's outsourcing of military resources post-Cold War a "mistake"? Knowing what we know now, what would you have done differently?

Key Terms

- [Strategic autonomy](#): Describes the EU's ambition to **minimise dependence** on external powers, in terms of **security and defence**. It can range from full self-sufficiency to closing capability gaps while still relying on NATO's support.
- [Production capability](#): It is a country's **ability** or **economic capability** to **manufacture defence equipment** at the scale needed to meet military demand.
- [National competence](#): It refers to a jurisdiction where **legal authority** rests with **individual Member States**, rather than the EU itself. Defence is mainly the responsibility of Member States, while the EU coordinates defence through the Common Security and Defence Policy (CSDP). National security remains the responsibility of each Member State under Article 4(2) TEU.
- [Burden-sharing](#): It is NATO's **core principle**, which states that Member States should **contribute proportionally** to the alliance's collective defence costs and capabilities.
- [Collective defence](#): Describes the principle that an **attack on one Member State** is treated as an **attack on all**, and it obliges others to respond.

Stakeholders

- **Directorate-General for Defence Industry and Space (DG DEFIS)**: the European Commission department responsible for security. It ensures the European Commission is the driving force behind nearly every **concrete initiative** in this area, including the [White Paper for European Defence](#) and the EU's funds (EDF, EDIP, ASAP, SAFE), aimed at reducing industrial fragmentation and strengthening the **European Defence Technological and Industrial Base (EDTIB)**.
- **North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO)**: is a **collective defence alliance** which aims to **safeguard** the security of its Member States through political and military means. Even though its fundamental competency is collective defence under [Article 5](#), it coordinates military planning, ensures interoperability, and has a key role in **transatlantic security cooperation**. Although 23 of its members are also members of the EU, NATO is **not an EU institution** and does not have legislative power over its members.
- **European External Action Service (EEAS)**: is the **EU's diplomatic service**. Its role is to promote peace, security and **European interests across the globe**. It runs the Common Security and Defence Policy ([CSDP](#)) and coordinates its missions, while managing the **diplomatic side** of the NATO-EU relationship. It's led by the High Representative, currently **Kaja Kallas**, who is also the [Vice-President](#) of the European Commission, to further ensure **coherence in EU foreign policy**.
- **Member States**: The EU is composed of **27 countries**, which share **core principles** and **values**, such as freedom, democracy and equality, while striving to **promote peace** and **stability**. However, decisions relating to the CSDP require **unanimity** under [Article 42 TEU](#). Given that frontline states, like Poland and the Baltics, hold [different threat perceptions](#) than southern states like Italy, Spain and Greece, **integration efforts** toward a common policy, like [PESCO](#), have repeatedly [underdelivered](#).
- **EDA**: It supports Member States in improving their defence capabilities through cooperation by running the [Coordinated Annual Review on Defence \(CARD\)](#). The EDA is also the [technical link](#) between **CARD, PESCO and the EDF**, since it ensures these measures **complement** rather than duplicate each other.

: Create a visual map showing how these stakeholders relate to each other, highlighting whatever dynamics you think are most relevant (power, dependence, tension, cooperation). The only requirement is that your map should show who really shapes EU defence policy, and why.

: Find one instance where the interests of two or more of these stakeholders could clash and describe it, representing each side's perspective.

Inside the Topic

Key Conflicts

Sovereignty and fragmented cooperation:

The **fragmentation** between the Member States' defence policies and their procurement systems has resulted in [incompatible military equipment](#) and persistent **capability gaps**. Although the EU Member States have **increased their expenditures** on security, up to [€381 billion in 2025](#), it has **not** translated into more **joint acquisition**. Combined with the fact that the [CSDP](#) states that any action under its area requires **unanimous agreement** between the Member States, this has made it really [difficult for the EU to create a common policy](#) while guaranteeing **national autonomy**. Moreover, in order to guarantee national autonomy to the Member States, this requirement also creates the possibility of placing [national interests](#) over the collective interests, because of **different threat perceptions** between the Northern and Southern states.

Strategic autonomy and transatlantic dependence:

Additionally, recent [threats to Europe's security](#), such as the US' pressure regarding the strategic status of Greenland, have repeatedly called into question [the US' commitment](#) to NATO's **Article 5**, which enshrines the **principle of collective defence**. At the same time, the EU still needs to **reinforce the NATO Alliance**. Although it is trying to fix decades of underinvestment in military security, the EU cannot easily replicate NATO's and its allies' **production capability**. This effort includes [investing in defence industries](#) that are part of [EDTIB](#), through the **European Defence Industry Programme (EDIP)**, and increasing their production capabilities. Furthermore, the EU's campaign to **incentivise** States to **buy European products** and favour the **European military market** has not been effective yet, since the [EU manufacturing countries cannot sustain production](#) on a large scale that could **support Europe's needs**.

Risks of a common defence:

Similarly, the fact that NATO and the EU **share** [23 Member States](#) is crucial, since they face the **same threats** but can combine **more resources**, which is fundamental to developing an **international** comprehensive **approach** to crisis management and operations. However, the

EU Member States that do not overlap are an [obstacle to a common policy](#). Finally, another major obstacle to an effective EU defence strategy is how the EU can [fund the increase](#) in defence spending **without diverting funds** from social welfare, and whether this common policy could actually make **Europe safer** or represent an initial step toward the [escalation](#) of [conflicts](#).

The Border Dilemma:

Leaving neighboring regions (such as the Western Balkans, Ukraine, or Moldova) in a geopolitical vacuum makes them [vulnerable to external influence and destabilisation](#) from rival global powers. By **expanding its borders**, the [EU integrates these areas into its normative, legal, and security frameworks](#). Absorbing neighboring territories extends the [EU's mutual defence clause](#) (Article 42.7 TEU), turning **potential flashpoints into stabilised, regulated zones**. Security policy and [common foreign policy \(CFSP\)](#) in the EU [rely heavily on unanimity](#). A larger Union with **more diverse national interests** increases the **risk of single-member vetoes** blocking crisis responses, diluting the EU's ability to act cohesively. Expanding borders brings the EU closer to volatile zones, [transforming external conflicts into internal European security responsibilities](#).

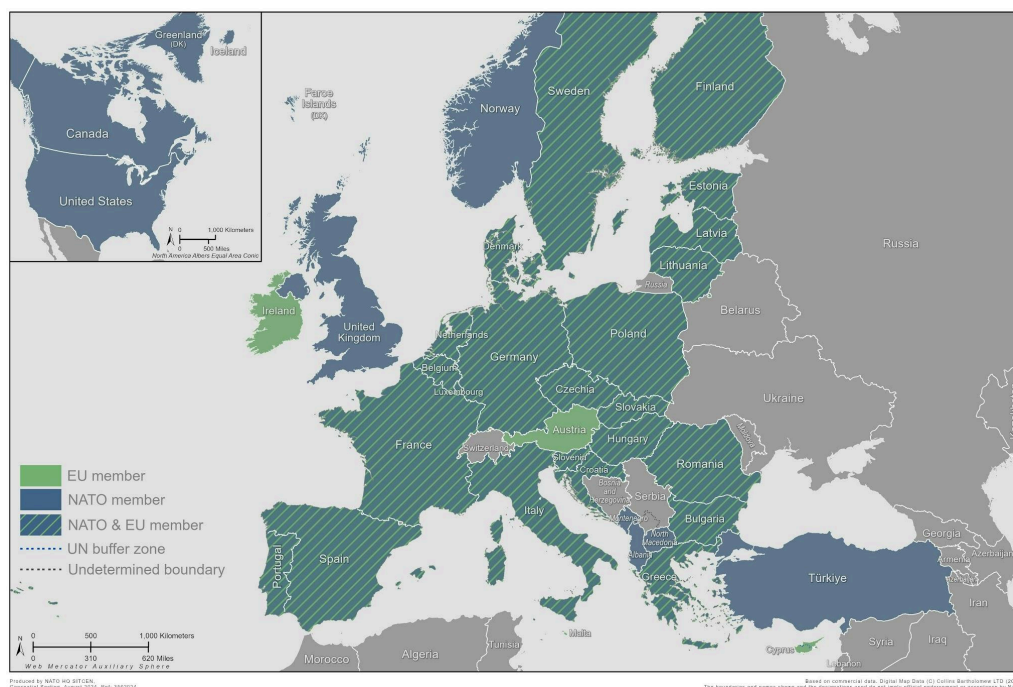


Figure 1: Differences and overlap between NATO and EU Member States (2024).

🛡️: Pick one conflict from this section, and imagine the EU does not address it for the next 10 years. Think about what that might look like in practice: what changes, who benefits, who suffers, and what Europe's security might look like by 2036. How would that future be different from today?

🛡️: Design a “trading card” for one conflict, and give it a name, a short description of what it's about, a 'strength' (why it matters) and a 'weakness' (why it's hard to resolve).

🛡️: Should the EU let Ukraine join quickly because of the war, or should Ukraine have to meet every standard rule first like every other candidate country?

Measures in Place

Given the [recent escalation of conflicts](#), the EU has implemented different **measures** to ensure a **common defence strategy**, with **financial instruments**, but also more **political** ones, all operating within the [Common Security and Defence Policy \(CSDP\)](#), which is the EU's framework for **coordinating civilian and military action**, and whose decisions require unanimity in the [Council of the European Union](#) under [Article 42 TEU](#).

One of the key measures is the [Permanent Structured Cooperation \(PESCO\)](#), which was [established](#) in 2017 between 26 Member States to **foster collaboration** within the EU and to support CSDP's operations. However, this cooperation has [not reached its full potential](#), with only [10% of projects](#) reaching operational development, while most of them **fail** to transition from concept to production. A prime example is [EU Battlegroups](#), a defence measure that has **never been deployed** due to [issues](#) regarding common political will and financial solidarity.

Furthermore, different measures that [provide funding](#) for defence industries, like the European Defence Fund ([EDF](#)) and European Defence Industry Programme ([EDIP](#)), aim to strengthen the EU's **defence industrial readiness** in order to [reduce investment fragmentation](#) between the Member States. Even though these funds aim to **enlarge EU military production**, they have mostly been divided between the [biggest defence contractors](#), like [Leonardo](#) (Italy) and [Thales](#) (France), which could be an [obstacle](#) to spreading **military capability EU-wide**.

Other measures in place that provide financial support to **close capability gaps** between the Member States and external countries are Security Action For Europe ([SAFE](#)), whose efficiency is limited by its [loan-based](#) nature, and the Act in Support of Ammunition Production ([ASAP](#)), which invested in ammunition production capacity, particularly to support [Ukraine's defence](#) against Russian attacks. Alongside these, the [White Paper for European Defence: Readiness 2030](#) stands out as one of the most recent and significant measures in place. It

aims to [rearm Europe](#) by boosting industrial production and facilitating **rapid deployment of military assets** across the EU.

: *Imagine you are responsible for one of these measures already in place, and have to report back to the EU on whether it worked. What would you highlight as a success or flag as a failure, and would you recommend renewing it, reforming it, or scrapping it?*

Further Understanding

Pillars of the Future

Given the [urgency of a common defence and security policy](#), the EU is [constantly discussing](#) the implementation of **new measures**. The establishment of Rapid Deployment Capacity ([RDC](#)), consisting of **modified EU Battlegroups** and additional force components. Financial funds reforms ([SAFE II](#)) that would shift different **funds from loans toward grants**. A new funding proposal, by the European Commission, for 2028-2035, that aims to create a €410 billion [European Competitiveness Fund](#), with €125 billion for defence. However, the path toward an effective and common EU defence policy is still uncertain, since core CSDP decisions still require [unanimity](#).

: *Given the fact that these measures are still just proposals, what would have to happen politically or economically in the next year for each one to actually become reality? Which feels most fragile to you?*

Test your skills

Consolidate your knowledge of the topic through some fun, interactive activities and whoever scores the most points will win a prize! You'll find a [quiz](#), a game where you [match each word](#) to the right conflict, and a [crossword puzzle](#) (with the [solutions](#) available here)